

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

P2P
Torrent: This is a small meta-data file and ends with .torrent. This torrent file contains all the information about those files (movies, music, etc) that you so eagerly want to download. When you try to initiate a P2P download, this file is sent to your computer.

Peer: A peer is another user just like you on the network or the Internet, who is interested in downloading stuff. A peer doesn't have the complete file on his/her system.

Seed: As the word goes, a seed is the originator of the file. The seed has the complete file on his/her system. There can be multiple seeds for the same file on the Internet, which is what makes P2P sharing so useful.

Swarm: A swarm is the whole bunch of people associated with a particular file. This includes the source of the file (or seed) and the peers downloading the file (others like you).

Tracker: The tracker is the server of the torrent site that monitors (or tracks) the progress of your download. When you initialise the agent, all it does is it communicates with the tracker and acquires a list of peers to contact. It tells you of the progress in file transfer.

DHT: This is an abbreviation for Distributed Hash Table. The tracker uses this table to compile a list of peers that host a particular file.

Usage: Last week, I used P2P file sharing to get that copy of *Titanic*. I got the *torrent* for it immediately. The *tracker* referred to the *DHT* and showed me 14 *seeds* and 50 *peers*. The whole *swarm* has grown tremendously this week.

Wild Wild Web

MAIL ORDER ADVICE Bride taken for a ride

The mail order bride phenomenon is nothing new. Most of these brides are selected based on Internet ads and they come to developed countries like Canada from countries in Asia and Africa. These women don't often get what they were promised and they are quite often unaware of their rights. They are duped to live in remote villages, and maybe even pushed into prostitution.

If these brides blame the Internet for getting them into this mess, they could

also look at the Internet for succour. A Web site, www.lawforforeignbrides.ca has been launched for these women by an organisation devoted to helping such people. There is nothing comic about this Web site which features information useful for new immigrants. However, we are sure you would see the irony in the whole situation. Of course there are a number of similar parallels: you install something dumb from the Internet which messes up your system and where do you turn for help? Why, another part of the Internet, of course.

CYBER CANINES It's a dog's blog

Dogs have joined humans in blogging. At maxthegoldenretriever.com, a blog chronicles the life of a golden retriever named Max. It's written in first person and talks of life from the point of view of a dog. Apparently Max is addicted to popcorn, talks about experiences with vets and annoyances with dry tennis balls.

His favourite channels are Animal Planet (expected) and Fox News (unexpected). His fave treat is ice cubes and his real name is Sir Maxwell Jones (a noble dog?). He is also allergic to cats.

OOOPS! WRONG WAY!

GPS-enabled Idiots

With GPS navigation systems making their mark among the roadies, also comes their way of getting into the limelight. Well, for good or bad depends on the eye of the beholder! These days, people in urban areas use GPS devices to guide themselves across their routes. However, at times, lessons are learnt the hard way—this is what Norman Sussman of New Mexico found out. Sussman asked his GPS unit for alternate directions after driving continually in heavy traffic.

Delighted on getting an alternate route, he ascended up a winding mountain road, hoping to join the interstate at another point. After nearly half an hour of turnings, Sussman came to a halt. He had just reached a 200-foot cliff!

Well, this is certainly not an isolated case, as commercials these days have started airing incidences of errors arising out of the use of GPS devices. In a popular

commercial for Nationwide Insurance, a man is seen crashing his car straight into a restaurant after following navigational instructions from his GPS device. Steve Schreibman, the firm's Vice President of advertising says the idea came from his own weird experiences with GPS. In a recent episode of the popular sitcom *The Office*, the character Michael drives straight into a lake, again due to faulty GPS navigation. Driving in the wrong direction and then realising it later would surely result in loads of swearing!

TALK STRAIGHT

Spin Detector

A professor from Queen's University has developed software that detects the political hoopla that candidates add into their speeches. David Skillicorn from the School of Computing at Queen's has some interesting findings from the election campaigns of the United States Presidential candidates. This software analyses the political speeches that the candidates deliver in each

round of campaigning. The methodology used by Skillicorn involves significant data mining and mathematical concepts. Over weeks of analyses, the software has found that John McCain emerges as the most honest in his speech. Barack Obama twists the most and Hillary Clinton comes in between the two. According to Skillicorn, there is a significant difference in the usage of terms like "we" and "I" in public speech. He added that people who tend to use "I" more often tend to be more responsible and honest in their outlook as compared to those who use "we". In general thought, it is quite unclear who the "we" is composed of! In addition, the software also uses terms like "but" and "or" in its calculation. This program uses the frequency of 86 key words to calculate a "spin" score for each speech. The higher the score, the lesser is the spin in the speech. Accordingly, McCain scored a healthy 2, Hillary a 0.6 and Obama was trailing with -1.3. We wonder what this software would conclude if tried out in India. Our *netas* would definitely score very high. Just which side of the scale is quite uncertain! Any takes?

KEEP AWAY FROM CHILDREN

Magneto!

Once in a while, we get to read of strange phenomena somewhere in the world. Sometimes it's radio broadcasts being heard from dental implants, sometimes it's the bizarre UFOs being spotted all over the place. The latest to make news is Joe Falciano III, a 12-year-old boy from Pulaski, New York. Apparently, when he just touches the computers he comes in contact with, they come to a standstill. The boy has become popular as "Magneto Man" and has found that every system he touches goes out of control. He was later suggested by his teacher to wear an anti-static belt at all times. His teachers are convinced that he has a static charge problem. According to Marie Yerdon, a teacher at Lura Sharp Elementary school in Pulaski, NY, whenever other students use the computers, they work perfectly fine. But as soon as Joe steps into the

Shattered Realities

We have a large container (50 litres, to be precise) of liquid nitrogen in our offices. No, this isn't the twilight zone—it didn't pop out of nowhere. There is a purpose to this. If only we knew what...

It's summer, and a rather uncomfortable one, at that. Perhaps this blessed fluid is here to make up for our perpetually malfunctioning air-conditioning system. Then again, perhaps it's for our entertainment.

It was love at first sight. The minute Badri (aka Badjag, aka *SKOAR!* Overlord) saw the tank, his face lit up. He vanished for a second, came back with his lunchbox, and poured the nitrogen into it: "Let's see what happens."

A few minutes later, we find Nimish (aka FatBeing)



entering the container's vicinity, all alight with a satanic grin that could bode only evil. Many experiments followed, and for those of you who aren't fortunate enough to encounter liquid nitrogen at such proximity, we present our findings:

1. Frozen roses shatter—like in the movies and the Discovery channel shows.
2. Frozen fruit is perfectly edible after un-freezing. Nutritional value unknown.
3. Frozen cloth crunches a bit, but returns to old state rather quick.
4. Liquid nitrogen makes for an effective, if expensive, floor cleaner.
5. Sanket does *not* approve of shattered flowers in the test centre.

If you have any ideas, or items / relatives you'd like shattered, do write in—offer valid only while stocks last!

scene, weird things happen. In fact, this static problem nearly failed him in his fifth-grade social studies class last year because his PowerPoint presentation was affected. While other students in the lab continued with their presentations, Joe and his teacher Yerdon spent time troubleshooting his PC. As Yerdon describes it, Joe would be in Microsoft Word, and suddenly be

unable to change the font. If he highlights a particular text, he may not be able to un-highlight it. He even gets upper case text without using the shift key! Worse still, he would save something, but then not be able to recover it! Finally, Yerdon put a grounding pad under the computer, which she connected to the anti-static wrist strap that Joe was wearing. The teacher said that the school has

purchased the equipment to protect students with pacemakers from electronic surges. However, in Joe's case, they had to protect the computer from him. Joe also faced similar problems with his Xbox at home. His parents have now replaced it with the wireless Xbox 360, which he enjoys as long as he is across the room away from the gaming console. Some magnetic personality, Joe! ■

Blog WATCH

Google's cold shoulder towards Microsoft's proposal to buyout Yahoo!, a MacBook Air user's experiences and Torrent sites being shut by media hype are part of this month's blog watch

Marshall Kirkpatrick
<http://tinyurl.com/3apoyg>
http://www.readwriteweb.com/archives/safari_on_windows_scam.php

Apple Takes the Spyware-Style Low Road, Pushing Safari on Windows
Debate is raging over the news that Steve Jobs has made good on his summertime promise and is now sending Apple's browser Safari along for the ride when Windows users are prompted to update iTunes or Quicktime. Users can deselect the additional software download, but let's be realistic—there must be millions of people unwittingly downloading Safari onto their computers right now....How many ways can you think of that Apple could grow its market share through innovation, instead of lowdown tactics like this?

Nate Anderson
<http://tinyurl.com/2ah4d9>
<http://arstechnica.com/articles/culture/nbc-media-moguls ars>

P2P is for piracy... and we're going to use it
Apparently, media moguls do not breakfast on a diet of puppies and children, as some consumers seem to think; bagels, toast, and oatmeal are the order of the day. George Kliavkoff, NBC's first "Chief Digital Officer," has also joined us to talk policy.

"I'm curious if you necessarily equate peer-to-peer protocols like BitTorrent with piracy?" I ask after the orange juice arrives...

Ryan Block
<http://tinyurl.com/37q46h>
<http://www.engadget.com/2008/03/26/motorola-insider-tells-all-about-the-fall-of-a-technology-icon/>
Motorola insider tells all about the fall of a technology icon

Like many (ourselves included), over the years Numair has become increasingly disenfranchised with the company's direction—enough so that he compelled us to publish his letter to Motorola, its board of directors, and MOT investors everywhere regarding the company's egregious missteps and mismanagement. In researching the myriad claims raised in this letter—which we believe to be true—we also discovered a number of other unsettling things about Motorola's corporate past in the last five years, such as certain gross corporate excesses demanded by Zander.

There's no doubt in our minds that Motorola is in dire straits. But today's news of the company's broken-off mobile division only serves to cement the fact that the company no longer knows how to conduct its core consumer business, and is squandering time and money as it flounders in a market that long since passed it by.